

Windows 7

In a freewheeling interview-cum-demo, the Digit team had a chat with Mr. Popli, Director - Windows Client, while the operating system was being showcased.

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For those who came in late, can you tell us what Windows 7 is all about?

The key theme around which Windows 7 was based was how it should work for the consumer and corporates. The thought that went into it was based on around 4,000 IT companies' feedback. It meant resolving all the expectations of consumers such as "I want it to be faster", "I want it to be smarter", and of course "it should be lighter on resources".

It is widely acknowledged that Vista less prone to malware, but the security came with a whole lot of notifications. So the question that consumers had was "do I need to be interrupted each time"? So with Windows 7 we left the choice up to the consumer.

With all its features, Windows 7 lets you make your life simple, lets you do exactly what you want to do and lets you do new things.

In the commercial environment direct access is one of the very big features offered by Windows 7. It's actually a replacement to a VPN. What direct access does, is let you directly access your corporate resources remotely, while giving you certain amount of savings. Branch cache and bit locker are also new features that are worth mentioning. All these features go to making the PC experience simplified, while taking care of security and risk management. IE8, which is also an integral part of Windows 7, has superior security and protection features.

Speaking of browsers, Google has announced the Chrome OS, which is to be based on a browser. What are your views?

We've not seen it yet, so it's very difficult to comment on it. All said and done even for the netbook phenomenon consumers have favoured or shown their preference for the Windows platform for reasons of its compatibility, eco-system experience and familiarity; even its interoperability with other devices.

Windows is giving upgrade options for Vista Premium and Ultimate users. Do you have similar options for netbook users? Especially since they don't come with an optical drive. Any options for USB boot?

I'll get back to you on that. However, in the new scheme of things, once the product is launched in October, netbook buyers will have the option of having Windows 7 preinstalled on their devices. Once that happens it will be a transparent experience. Windows Anytime Upgrade options are also available on Windows 7 for field upgrade using a key. To upgrade from, say, a Starter Edition to Ultimate.

Will Windows 7 also come with a Starter Edition, like Windows XP?

Yes, Windows 7 Starter Edition will be available for small-form factors including netbooks.



Will it have a three-application limit that XP had?

No, there won't be any three application limits this time with Windows 7.

What about anti-piracy measures? Does Windows 7 offer any sophisticated form of anti-piracy technique, compared to previous versions that sported the online validation tool?

Windows 7 will come with the Genuine Advantage Program with automatic update. Those are the ones that will be a driving tool, so that consumers will see that having legitimate software will be of value to them. Partners loose out since there's not much value coming through in terms of overall business proposition. Lastly, the economy's obviously a loser since the government gets nothing back in the form of tax behind every product sale.

What is the Windows 7 pricing going to be? We've seen that the pricing for consumers has been slashed compared to Windows Vista in the US. Will this be reflected here in India as well?

At a broad level, the prices will be cheaper. I can't really give you an exact figure, but approximately it would be in the range of 10-15 per cent lower.

We've seen a trend of software moving towards the cloud. Google is coming up with its browser-centred Chrome OS. Already, there are many cloud-based OSes out there. What are Microsoft's plans to take on the 'cloud'?

Our view of the cloud is very clear; it's going to be a combination. It's going to be a combination of a platform-like PC which has its own abilities to run applications. Because there's no comparison to the user-experience across the board to have every thing on the cloud. There are certain services that will be on the cloud. There's value for certain applications to be on the cloud. Does it mean that what you need on an everyday basis has to be only on the cloud? Unlikely. And why would you do that? Can you imagine one billion users today to be on the cloud, all the time? Potentially not. Let's talk of our own country, how many people are really going to be on the cloud, all the time? The speeds currently are not worthy of giving us a real-life experience.

As a trend, increasingly, more and more services are going to be on the cloud. Today, you have IM and mail on the cloud. This is recognition that more people are spending more time on the cloud. But does it mean its going to be black and white, all cloud and no client? I think that's a very unlikely scenario. Which is why Microsoft has stated that our direction is to continue to work and enhance the services on the cloud. But the versatility of the PC platform, the richness of what it can offer, in a combination with the cloud is the direction to move forward. 